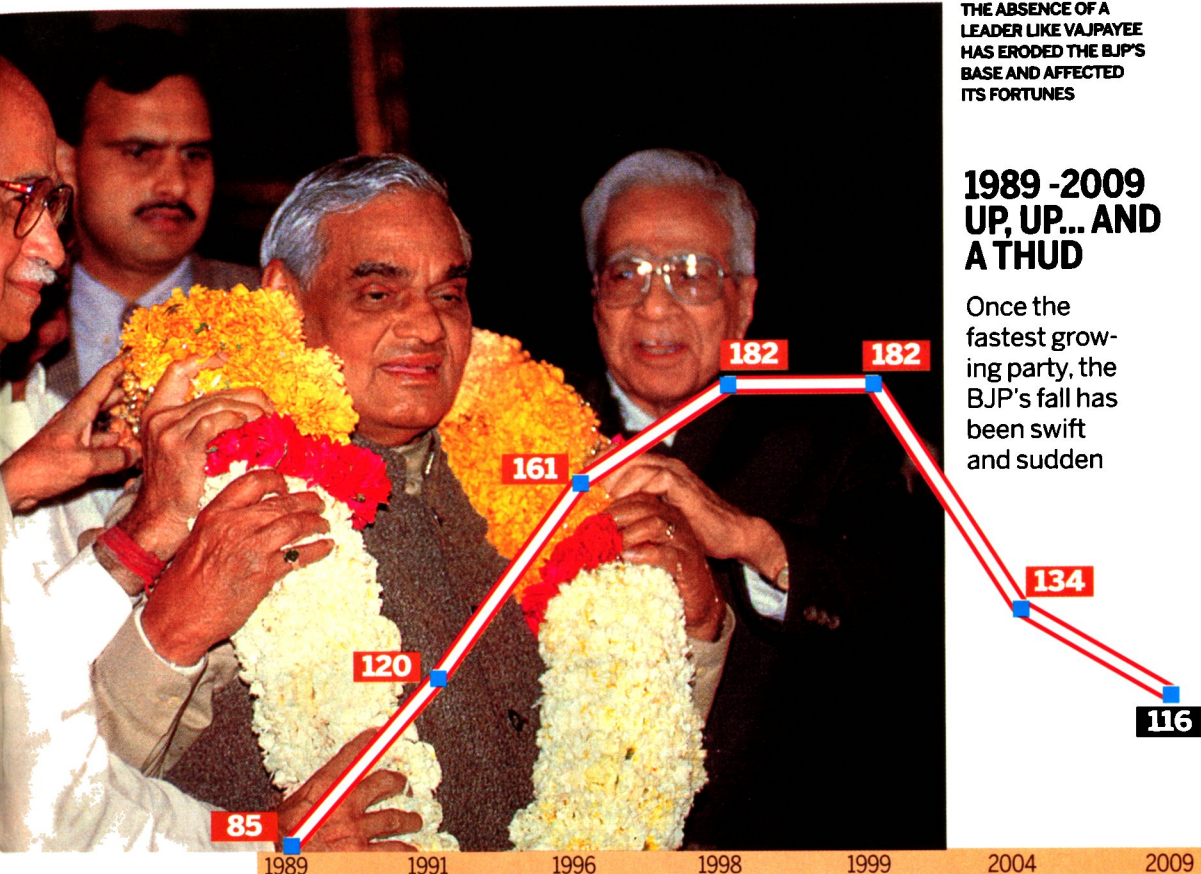


SHARAD SAXENA

THE ABSENCE OF A LEADER LIKE VAJPAYEE HAS ERODED THE BJP'S BASE AND AFFECTED ITS FORTUNES

1989-2009 UP, UP... AND A THUD

Once the fastest growing party, the BJP's fall has been swift and sudden



the verge of losing their perks and posts. Instead of rewarding the winners and those who steered the party to victory in some states, Advani chose to reward the architects of the defeat. Despite stiff opposition, Advani appointed Jaitley as Leader of the Opposition in Rajya Sabha which carries the rank of a cabinet minister along with all accompanying perks. Jaitley is one of the best parliamentarians but his colleagues consider the legal eagle to be a part-time politician. His elevation was seen by many as Advani's effort to consolidate his control over the party and deny any substantial role to other senior leaders.

For the first time, the party had no management role in the election, which was handed to a bunch of favourites in the party and outside. Eventually, the election was fought around Advani's personality and not the party's ideology.

The problem was compounded by Advani himself by not being clear about the line to follow—Hindutva or an extension of Brand Vajpayee. The ideological mismatch did not fool voters, not the least its middle class base. Little wonder then that the letter writers are insisting that the BJP should now be led by those who have an ideological stake in it.

THE CHALLENGE FROM WITHIN

The crisis in the BJP would perhaps have not assumed such proportions if the party had not been allowed to be hijacked by a handful of leaders, who have over the last decade or so got a stranglehold on it. In the process, many others, genuine winners who carry more conviction with the cadres, were sidelined. And it is they who are now challenging the establishment and the "Cosmetic Generation". When former ministers Yashwant Sinha, Jaswant Singh and Arun Shourie chose to break their si-



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